

Monday, December 5

Peter is singing 'minipops': 'Ah wanna leeeve foravuh.' He's stretching up. The crown of his head is higher than the China cabinet surface.

Piano lessons began Saturday. Kelsey and DJ attended as well. They did rhythms. Peter enjoyed himself. Now he stands at our piano and picks out tunes, mostly from his cello books.

Matthew is busy at the piano also. He plays with both thumbs. He slides along the bench, using up all the keys, turning pages of the book. During supper he ate holding and patting Monchichi. He sat on the sofa tonight, laughing all the way through the sitcom WKRP, swinging his feet. Mama and Papa came over to watch The Best Christmas Pageant Ever, a TV production with Kristen Skarsgard in a small role. Matthew went about with Peter's gym shorts on his head.

Weather: -12. Islam extremists are using car bombs in Beirut. Trudeau's peace mission is over. His last stop is Kuwait.

Year End (written January 8, 1984)

It has been a long time since my last entry.

The F:11 pictures weren't satisfactory. The boys sat too far apart in some. We had too few decent options. Jerry had told us to make sure we found something we liked. We took him at his word and arranged another sitting. The second time around was much better. The final package arrived before Christmas. Peter's cello pictures needed retouching and won't be ready until the middle of January. The one we've chosen, Jerry says, is good enough to blow up and hang in their studio. Cheryl's parents ordered several of the four of us. They are framed and hang in our hallway.

Cheryl is a stately queen.

Peter is bright-eyed and keen.

Matthew wears his usual pout.

I more than want to ink me out.

The Christmas pre-season was a frustration with countless and ceaseless trivial arrangements and preparations here at home and at our respective schools. With little to remember of any of it, we are left tired and edgy. The relatives gathered time and again: Cheryl's family on Christmas Eve, with Peter playing 'Twinkle', 'Allegro' and 'Rigadoon', singing 'The Straw is Yellow', 'Come On Ring Those Bells', and reciting two poems. One was:

God gave his son
In Christmas love
To all the World
From Heaven Above
An Angel brought
The glorious word
And shepherds knelt
Before the Lord.
God gave his Son
In Christmas love
What is your gift
To God above?

We spent Christmas Eve at Cheryl's parent's place and opened more gifts in the morning. As proof of Santa being there, Peter claimed he saw 'a bit of red'. A gift had been left that turned out to be a 'Trail Boss' rifle and a physics set, an Alpha Star and Alpha Interceptor, some books. That's Christmas: a 'bit of red' and lots of 'bread'.

We spent the afternoon at my parents'. The family was together (excluding Michael and Cathy, but including Aunt Anne, Grandma, and Mr. and Mrs.

Kardash) for open-face sandwiches. We left at 6 and returned to Cheryl's parents for turkey supper with Crystal, Ione and Adolph Peters.

By Boxing Day we had regained control of our schedule. Far less racing to stores and dusting furniture. The afternoon was spent at Grandma Hedlin's at Luther Towers with Aunt Anne and Uncle Leslie. Carol and Les arrived later. The small apartment got too hot, so the five boys chased up and down the hallway. I sort of supervised. The boys stopped what they were doing when a woman came out of her place and stood at the elevator. She said something to give the impression she believed all the boys were mine.

Michael and Cathy arrived December 28. We ate at Carol's December 29 around an oval table. Eleven of the siblings and partners went to Villi's on the 30th for supper. We enjoyed it until someone began throwing ice. The bill came to \$207.80. We subdivided the amount. Everyone added their own tips, except Ernie. Les and I made up his deficiency. The city lights are a pleasing backdrop. Matthew, Cheryl, Michael, Cathy and Joel came to our place afterwards.

Matthew and Cheryl left on Friday. Cheryl was clearly unhappy about being separated from her family.

We went to Mrs. Gyorgy's for New Year's Eve. We played Trivial Pursuit and left before the food was served. Since Christmas Eve the weather has improved, the temperatures have risen to +5. We've almost forgotten the three preceding weeks of -40.

School started up on Wednesday, January 4. Peter didn't want to go. (Cheryl had visited the principal Harvey Welch about Mrs Lymin. Perhaps she still doesn't know if a boy named Peter is in her class. She is inattentive to the point of neglect. Harvey said he'd speak to the teacher. He advised Cheryl to give it two weeks. If there was no improvement by then, he'd understand if we pulled Peter out. It's a tough decision. While Peter isn't happy about school, he does have a pair of new Bauer ice skates.

We were soon back into our routine. We spend until 8 with the boys, and once they're in bed we begin our personal business.

In this time the boys are changing. They are more like brothers. The dynamics are increasingly complex. Matthew is bigger, more of a character, more a

manipulator, funnier, more demanding, etc. Peter allows himself to be led around the house, back and forth in the hallway, to the piano where they punch out their favourite 'melodies', under the desk in the kitchen, into the living room to wrestle, or into Peter's bedroom, which usually ends with a competition for Peter's things. Peter is a gallant brother, resisting the temptation to dominate Matthew. But that means Matthew dominates Peter, shrieking out his will and taking his pick of Peter's toys. In general Peter is reserved, thoughtfully spoken, though there are times of emotion and frustration. Matthew is chubby, Peter is ever taller and wiry. Matthew jabbars endlessly. Peter speaks sometimes about becoming a 'Space Scientist'. If the boys were ever in the company of the Queen of England, they'd drop her the instant Papa entered the room. He's better since his surgery. I'm going in for the same thing on January 15th.

Matthew's words: shoes, there it is, all done, Peter.

Peter's words: well, he hasn't cursed in a while.